

Primary Source Reading 2: The Road to Larissa and the Gift of the Statesmen

Optima Academy Online | Philosophy & Ethics | High School Honors (9–12) From Plato's Meno, translated by Benjamin Jowett Read before Lesson 4b: Knowledge vs. True Opinion

Before you read: Socrates and Meno have agreed that true opinion can guide action just as well as knowledge — at least some of the time. Socrates now works out exactly what that “at least some of the time” means, using an example about giving directions. He then turns to a harder case: the great statesmen of Athens, who acted well without, it seems, ever being able to explain why. As you read, notice what each example shows that the other does not.

The Road to Larissa

SOCRATES: If a man knew the way to Larisa, or anywhere else, and went to the place and led others thither, would he not be a right and good guide?

MENO: Certainly.

SOCRATES: And a person who had a right opinion about the way, but had never been and did not know, might be a good guide also, might he not?

MENO: Certainly.

SOCRATES: And while he has true opinion about that which the other knows, he will be just as good a guide if he thinks the truth, as he who knows the truth?

MENO: Exactly.

SOCRATES: Then true opinion is as good a guide to correct action as knowledge; and that was the point which we omitted in our speculation about the nature of virtue, when we said that knowledge only is the guide of right action; whereas there is also right opinion. (97a–c)

The Statues of Daedalus

SOCRATES: You would not wonder, if you had ever observed the images of Daedalus... Because they require to be fastened in order to keep them, and if they are not fastened they will play truant and run away.

MENO: Well, what of that?

SOCRATES: I mean to say that they are not very valuable possessions if they are at liberty, for they will walk off like runaway slaves; but when fastened, they are of great value, for they are really beautiful works of art. Now this is an illustration of the nature of true opinions: while they abide with us they are beautiful and fruitful, but they run away out of the human soul, and do not remain long, and therefore they are not of much value until they are fastened by the tie of the cause; and this fastening of

them, friend Meno, is recollection... But when they are bound, in the first place, they have the nature of knowledge; and, in the second place, they are abiding. And this is why knowledge is more honourable and excellent than true opinion, because fastened by a chain. (97d–98a)

[Socrates turns to Anytus, a prominent Athenian, and asks him to consider the most admired statesmen the city has produced — men whose virtue no one disputes.]

The Sons of Great Men

SOCRATES: Would you not admit that Themistocles was a good man?

ANYTUS: Certainly; no man better.

SOCRATES: And must not he then have been a good teacher, if any man ever was a good teacher, of his own virtue? ... Did you never hear that he made his son Cleophantus a famous horseman, and had him taught to stand upright on horseback and hurl a javelin, and to do many other marvellous things; and in anything which could be learned from a master he was well trained?

ANYTUS: I have.

SOCRATES: But did any one, old or young, ever say in your hearing that Cleophantus, son of Themistocles, was a wise or good man, as his father was?

ANYTUS: I have certainly never heard any one say so. (93c–94a)

SOCRATES: There is Pericles, again, magnificent in his wisdom; and he, as you are aware, had two sons, Paralus and Xanthippus... he taught them to be unrivalled horsemen, and had them trained in music and gymnastics and all sorts of arts — in these respects they were on a level with the best — and had he no wish to make good men of them? Nay, he must have wished it. But virtue, as I suspect, could not be taught. (94b)

[Anytus grows angry at this line of questioning and warns Socrates to be careful about speaking ill of prominent men. Socrates turns back to Meno and draws the conclusion the evidence seems to require.]

Divine, Not Wise

SOCRATES: And therefore not by any wisdom, and not because they were wise, did Themistocles and those others of whom Anytus spoke govern states. This was the reason why they were unable to make others like themselves — because their virtue was not grounded on knowledge.

MENO: That is probably true, Socrates.

SOCRATES: But if not by knowledge, the only alternative which remains is that statesmen must have guided states by right opinion, which is in politics what divination is in religion; for diviners and also prophets say many things truly, but they know not what they say. And may we not, Meno, truly call those men “divine” who, having no understanding, yet succeed in many a grand deed and word?

MENO: Certainly.

SOCRATES: To sum up our enquiry — the result seems to be, if we are at all right in our view, that virtue is neither natural nor acquired, but an instinct given by God to the virtuous. Nor is the instinct accompanied by reason, unless there may be supposed to be among statesmen some one who is capable of educating statesmen. *(99b–100a)*

MENO: That is excellent, Socrates.

SOCRATES: Then, Meno, the conclusion is that virtue comes to the virtuous by the gift of God. But we shall never know the certain truth until, before asking how virtue is given, we enquire into the actual nature of virtue. *(100b)*